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CONCRETE AMBIVALENCE: INSIDE THE BUNKER COMPLEX

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ABSTRACT The defensive systems of fortified bunkers built during the twentieth century have become, especially since the end of the Cold War, an object of troubled fascination for artists, architects, and archaeologists. Images of bunkers proliferate in contemporary art and photography, and the heritage business has become increasingly interested in exploiting public curiosity towards the remains of recent conflict. This article positions current work about bunkers within the context of postwar debates surrounding modernist aesthetics – minimalism in art, brutalism in architecture – and the latent connection between modernist concerns regarding shape, form, and materials and military construction. Recent interest in bunkers is linked, it is argued, to the ongoing

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reappraisal of postwar modernist art and architecture and its relationship not only to the violence of World War Two but to the secrecy and passive aggression of the Cold War. As such, the bunker as a site of power in much of the work discussed is approached not merely as an historical artifact but as a deeply ambivalent structure that speaks to contemporary anxieties regarding the location and accountability of the systems of authority and control the bunker represents.

KEYWORDS: bunker, ambivalence, militarism, photography, brutalism, heritage.

> Early in W. G. Sebald's novel *Austerlitz* (2002), the architectural historian Jacques Austerlitz surmises that it is "often our mightiest projects that most obviously betray the degree of our insecurity" (16). This observation is made during a conversation about the folly of military fortifications which, Austerlitz argues, however technically sophisticated they may be, rarely provide the kind of defensive assurance their design and construction promises. A heavily fortified town draws fire as an obviously valuable enemy asset; complex barricades prompt sensible officers to lead the advance elsewhere; and large defensive systems can take so long to build that they are outmoded before they are finished. The immediate context of Austerlitz's comments is the system of ringed defenses around the Belgian city of Antwerp, begun in 1859 and periodically modified and extended up until the building of the fortress of Breendonk in 1906. By this time the fortifications were already near-useless in the face of modern weapons and many were destroyed by the German artillery during World War One. Breendonk became a Nazi prison and transit camp during World War Two, the incarcerated forced to disinter the fort by hand by removing a huge layer of topsoil and using it to build a concealing wall around it. Used again as a prison after the war to house collaborators, Breendonk was designated a National Memorial in 1947.

Prompted by his conversation with Austerlitz, Sebald's narrator visits Breendonk, carrying in his mind an image of "a star-shaped bastion with walls towering above a precise geometrical ground-plan" (25). Instead, what he encounters is a "low-built concrete mass" that is "hunched and misshapen" like the "broad back of a monster," a structure "so far exceeding [his] comprehension" that he is "unable to connect it with anything shaped by human civilization, or even with the silent relics of our prehistory and early history" (25–6). Riddled with "open ulcers" and "encrusted with guano-like droppings," the fort is nothing but a "monolithic, monstrous incarnation of ugliness and blind violence" (26). *Austerlitz* is not the first time Sebald has had occasion to describe military structures in these terms. In *The Rings of Saturn* (1998), the famous concrete pagodas on the shingle spit at Orford Ness in Suffolk, England that were once part of a secret military installation, seem "like the remains of our own civilization after its extinction in some future

Figure 1
Cornford & Cross, "Pagoda" bunker, Orford Ness, Suffolk, 2005. Courtesy of Cornford & Cross.

catastrophe" (237). The concrete bunkers here look "like the tumuli in which the mighty and powerful were buried in prehistoric times with all their tools and utensils, silver and gold" (236). Lost in space and time, the narrator is bewildered by the "enigma" the place represents (Figure 1).

In each of Sebald's descriptions of an encounter with the remains of military constructions the monstrous presence of the structure does not ground historical understanding but is instead radically destabilizing. The buildings either seem to have been thrown to earth from some other place or else the visitor himself has been transported through time to glimpse the ruins of the future. The point of these reflections is not to uncouple fortifications from the history that has produced them but rather to identify something in bunkers that resists assimilation. For Sebald, the bunker itself generates its own dehistoricizing effect as a kind of negative monument that commemorates an absence and a forgotten context. In the face of its concrete blankness, pre- and post-historical imaginings fill the space evacuated by the bunker's refusal to yield an account of itself. Sebald's discussion of Breendonk and Orford Ness registers something of the challenge presented by relics of conflict, the ways in which the past is both confirmed and denied by their obstinate presence, and the unease that such structures continue to generate.

The bunker is both anomalous and ubiquitous in contemporary culture, the embodiment of contradictory implications that, as Jacques Austerlitz says, "betray the degree of our insecurity." One of the most compelling contradictions that bunkers appear to articulate and which animates much of the cultural work about them is the sense that bunkers are at the same time necessary and useless. The solidity of the reinforced bunker invokes both the power of the weapons it is intended to repel and something of the folly of the attempt to seek any sort of shelter from them. As such, the bunker is both a sign

of industrialized warfare and of there being no escape from it. The continuing fascination with Hitler's bunker has its source not only in the imagined thoroughness with which Nazi space was militarized, but in the fact that it ultimately offered no protection. The satisfaction in knowing that Hitler could not secret himself from Allied assault gives the lie to the bunker's promise of security but in doing so inadvertently also calls into question the usefulness of the bunker as defensive redoubt. Hitler himself had already demonstrated this by steering his invasion of France around the Maginot Line.

The bunker's redundancy as a mode of defense is seemingly confirmed by the remains of thousands of pillboxes, blockhouses, fallout shelters, flak towers, observation posts, gun turrets, command centers, and test sites that litter cities, coastlines, and landscapes from rural East Anglia to Kinmen Island in the Taiwan Strait. These are the ruins of the twentieth century, of ideologies, conflicts, and dreams of mastery through reinforced concrete. Yet the reassuring pastness of the ruin's conventional aesthetic function is not so easily achieved by the wrecked or abandoned bunker, which continues to shape and structure affective responses to the environment within which it squats. "It is hard," writes Robert Macfarlane of Orford Ness, to "not feel its militarising influence upon one's vision. That day, everything I saw seemed bellicose, mechanised. A hare exploded from a shingle divot. Bramble coiled and looped like barbed wire. Geese landed with their undercarriages down. Green and orange lichen camouflaged the concrete of pillboxes" (2007: 257). Military ruins here are not discrete objects within the field of vision but saturate the experience of being in a landscape that subversively militarizes the natural and naturalizes the military. Unlike the Romantic ruin, which relies upon nature's persistent embrace to take the edges off sharp historical relics, for Macfarlane the abandoned military site continues instead to harden and technologize the surroundings. The past to which the bunker stands as evidence is not over but remains the condition of possibility within which the present must be apprehended.

Military sites like Orford Ness influence vision in the way Macfarlane describes for the simple reason that the bunkers are there to be seen. As the fortress complex at Antwerp described by Sebald demonstrates, the technologies of modern warfare have required defensive installations to be, above all else, hidden, and part of what disorients Sebald's narrators and what militarizes Macfarlane's prose is the fact that what ought to be concealed has become visible. Rendering the invisible visible is a sign of security's undoing and the disquiet experienced when the otherwise veiled realm of military occupation is exposed to the field of vision is a measure of the insecurity that is at the heart of the bunker's ambivalent status.[1]

While the bunker promises security and control in the form of refuge it is also a sign of the deadly power that requires reinforced shelter; a bunker is both womb- and tomb-like, generating precisely the kind of attraction/repulsion ambivalence Freud discusses in *Totem and Taboo*

as the characteristic polarity of modern affective life (Freud 1919). Zygmunt Bauman explains that ambivalence refers to "the possibility of assigning an object or an event to more than one category" (1991: 1). As a failure of language's naming function, ambivalence generates, according to Bauman, "acute discomfort" (1) when situations, objects, or actions cannot be accurately or adequately assigned an unambiguous meaning. Modernity's pursuit of order has therefore been a protracted war on ambivalence, yet the classification systems that have sought to reduce chaos by fragmenting and regulating the world have in fact only served to generate more ambivalence. For Bauman, "ambivalence is *the waste of modernity*" and modernity's "most genuine worry and concern, since unlike other enemies, defeated or enslaved, it grows in strength with every success of modern powers. It is its own failure that the tidying-up activity construes as ambivalence" (15; italics in original).

As a sign of modern industrial warfare, the bunker embodies violence either achieved or promised. But, as we have seen, a visible bunker is to a large extent disarmed, though its military function is overwritten by its uncanny affective power as something hidden that has come to light. The control of the environment the bunker's presence was supposed to ensure – the war machine's capacity to secure and hold territory; to produce order from chaos and thereby reduce ambivalence – is, postwar, apparently no longer relevant. And yet as Macfarlane suggests, the bunker maintains a hold on its environment that cannot properly return to a state of peace but must forever be informed by its militarized condition. The bunker's capacity to generate discomfort of the kind registered by Sebald and Macfarlane is complicated and troublesome; indeed, as Bauman suggests, any attempt to grasp or secure the bunker's significance is likely to produce more ambivalence and contradiction. The bunker as such is disruptively anomalous and defies categorization and stability of function and significance. Oscillating somewhere between the visible and the invisible, architecture and engineering, ruins and rubble, violence and inertia, the spectacularly symbolic and the blankly dumb, the bunker is the waste of modernity that cannot be tidied away.

In the case of Orford Ness, after existing for the best part of a century as a Ministry of Defence secret, the National Trust established the site as a nature reserve in 1993; visitors are divided between birdwatchers and military installation enthusiasts. According to Christopher Woodward, a conscious decision was made not to demolish the pagodas and other structures on the Ness because the site, it was felt, ought to be left as a palimpsest of twentieth-century history and allowed to poetically erode back into dust. Woodward, like Sebald and Macfarlane, recognizes the odd fusion of the organic and the technological at the site, writing that the "labs seem half-man, half-Nature" (2002: 224). Unlike Macfarlane, though, Woodward prefers a Romantic gloss, reading the bunkers not as phenomenologically contaminated and contaminating but merely "as banal as any industrial desolation [. . .]. The Cold War is over" (224). Woodward is too willing to adopt the language of closure here, and

while it could be argued that the National Trust has managed to hold in tension the apparent antinomies of militarized landscape and nature reserve, the site's power cannot be shut down so easily. Even though he quotes Sebald at length, Woodward fails to address the discomfort and foreboding in Sebald's assessment of the Ness which, as I have already noted, apprehends "the remains of our own civilization after its extinction in some future catastrophe" (1998: 237). The Cold War is over, but it is not an ending.

AMBIVALENT TYPOLOGIES

While the defensive structures of World War Two were either dismantled or abandoned and ignored, the installations of the Cold War that replaced them were in large part unseen and unknowable to anyone outside those with security clearance. As such, for many years Cold War bunkers could only be imagined, as in the sprawling subterranean command posts of films like *Fail Safe* (1964) or *Dr. Strangelove* (1964), or rendered in surrogate form by the institutional modernism of post-war brutalism. The immediate legacy of vast wartime bunker-building programs was rarely acknowledged at the time as an influence on the design and implementation processes of postwar planners and architects, a measure of how thoroughly the bunker's ambivalent status – its absent presence – had become a defining condition of the state of permanent global war.

Paul Virilio began investigating the remains of the World War Two-era German-built Atlantic Wall fortifications along the French coast in 1958. A seven-year period of exploration and documentation resulted in an exhibition of photographs and texts in Paris in 1975–6. This work was published in an English translation in 1994 under the title *Bunker Archeology* (Virilio 1994; Gane 2000: 86). As well as the now-famous photographs of the bunkers themselves, the book offers a series of historical, architectural, and phenomenological ruminations on the structures, along with maps and diagrams providing a typology of the fortifications. The project is at once archeological and historical in its desire to provide accurate documentation of the bunkers and their significance, and also architectural in its concern to place the buildings within the context of European modernism. There is, in addition, however, a powerful aesthetic dimension to *Bunker Archeology* that suggests something of the work of the influential Düsseldorf-based artists Bernd and Hilla Becher, who began their own typological documentation of industrial structures around the same time that Virilio became interested in the bunkers (Lange 2006). The Bechers described their collection of images of water towers, mine heads, and gas tanks as taxonomies of "anonymous sculptures," suggesting, *pace* Duchamp, their status as found objects capable of generating precisely the kind of ambivalence between architecture and engineering captured in Virilio's scrutiny of bunkers. The peculiarities of industrial structures, for the Bechers, "originate not in spite of, but because of lack of design" (quoted in Zweite 2004: 9), and it is this apparent absence of design that enabled

military construction to evade acknowledgment from architects even as its forms were being utilized in city centers, new towns, and university campuses across Europe and North America.

The exhibition of Virilio's project in the mid 1970s came just after the publication of one of the first attempts to survey the military architecture of the twentieth century, Kevin Mallory and Arvid Ottar's *Architecture of Aggression* (1973). The preface to this book explains that the authors originally set out to establish a link between modern architecture and military construction – something Virilio's work also explores – but since they found little significant secondary material on twentieth century military building their main job became inventorial. One of the reasons why there was no sustained architectural study of military construction before the 1970s is because it was not considered to be architecture at all. Mallory and Ottar quote Michael Waterhouse, the honorary secretary of the Royal Institute of British Architects, dismissing military building in 1943 as merely "a combination of Organisation and Improvisation." Such building "cannot be called Architecture," sniffed Waterhouse, "either as we knew it – or as we know it ought to be" (Mallory and Ottar 1973: 9). For Waterhouse, the military structure, as an engineering solution to a practical problem, is inconceivable in architectural terms. The military-industrial look of postwar buildings by Le Corbusier, Alison and Peter Smithson, and a host of lesser known city architects like Birmingham's John Madin, was a deliberate challenge to the aesthetic conservatism of establishment figures like Waterhouse, though the purported functionalism of modernist architecture was often an alibi for what was primarily a concern with effect. As Reyner Banham argues, if the "form follows function" edict had been followed scrupulously "there would be no way in which a design school could look like a factory" (1989: 7). There may be sound reasons why Madin's Birmingham library was built to resemble a flak tower, but necessity is unlikely to be among them (Figure 2).

Figure 2
John Madin, Birmingham Central Library, Chamberlain Square, Birmingham, 1974. Prince Charles famously noted that the library looked more like a building for burning books than for keeping them.

If modern architecture was more concerned with style than function, what Virilio's bunker archaeology does is force into view that which is repressed by the utopian futurism of postwar international modernism: that the passive aggressive look and feel of modernist building projects draw upon the affective and symbolic weight of the military bunker and thereby continue the legacy of militarized space they purport to replace.[2] At the same time, Virilio's attention to exposed structures that should otherwise remain concealed speaks to the impact of a revealed militarized environment that chimes with Macfarlane's experience at Orford Ness. The bunker, writes Virilio, "is spun from a network under tension with the landscape and, through the landscape, with the region in its expanse. It is an invisible and immaterial network that escapes our gaze and enables the bunker to hide from view and to avoid shocks" (1994: 44). To fulfill its defensive function the bunker must be hidden and naturalized: "[l]inked to the ground, to the surrounding earth, the bunker, for camouflage, tends to coalesce with the geological forms whose geometry results from the forces and exterior conditions that for centuries have modeled them" (1994: 44). Once exposed, it is not only the combatant who is vulnerable to the shock of assault but also the viewer who has had the "invisible and immaterial network" of militarized forces thrust into view.

Virilio's work dissolves the phony distinction between bunkers and modern buildings, a distinction that served as a classificatory containment of the bunker's real and symbolic violence. But while the aestheticized "architectural" bunker surrogates that became the default style of Cold War state modernism appropriated the effect of the military installation's look of defiance, they also served to deflect the gaze away from the sites of real power, which were anonymously installed elsewhere. As we have seen, effective bunkers are hidden; only redundant bunkers can be seen. An architectural style based on operationally compromised fortifications is patently more interested in form than function, and brutalism's performative machismo works as a mode of camouflage or misdirection since real Cold War architecture, as Tom Vanderbilt has argued, is less about buildings and more concerned with the web of "security arrangements" that maintained order (2002: 16). Most effective Cold War military buildings were indeed hidden and even those, like the Pentagon, which could be viewed from the outside kept their interiors secret. What was secret, Vanderbilt explains, "was often right out in the open, and what was 'bunkerlike' was often far removed from traditional connotations of defense" (2002: 124).

Virilio's Atlantic Wall explorations are, I think, as much a response to the concealments of Cold War power as they are an historical excavation of the militarization of space during World War Two. By approaching bunkers as sculptural and architectural forms rather than just as monstrous fascist excrescences, he allows room for the aesthetic within the realm of the barbarous and also brings together wartime engineering with postwar modernism. Interrogating the visibility of "dead" bunkers and buildings that look like bunkers calls forth an

awareness of other unseen bunkers that are in use, the dead bunkers gesturing toward unknown "live" continuations of their legacy (see Saunder 1996). Virilio argues that "[t]he bunker has become a myth, present and absent at the same time: present as an object of disgust instead of a transparent and open civilian architecture, absent insofar as the essence of the new fortress is elsewhere, underfoot, invisible from here on in" (Virilio 1994: 46). A wrecked bunker is never safe since its very presence speaks to the continuation of its power elsewhere.If the bunker's ambivalence has made its status as architecture a matter of dispute, the aesthetic awkwardness of military structures is also a challenge when considering the bunker as ruin. For Paul Hirst, the idea of a ruin "involves a highly particular aesthetic" that does not apply to bunkers, which are neither heroic nor ancient and as such cannot properly be described as picturesque (2005: 215). While they may well be in a state of advanced disrepair, the aesthetic features of bunkers are, for Hirst, "*sui generis*, a function of their form and site, and those are not altered by the fact the building is no longer in use" (2005: 215). As a block of concrete, disuse or damage does not change the basic form of a bunker; instead, it is often, as we have seen, its incongruous presence in a landscape that makes the bunker remarkable.

Growing interest in the wreckage and remains of war has led to a significant modification of the definition of what constitutes a ruin. While concurring with Hirst that bombs produce rubble and not ruins, in recent years, Andreas Huyssen has observed, the market has "been saturated with stunning picture books and films [. . .] of the ruins of World War Two. In them, rubble is indeed transformed, even aestheticized, into ruin" (2006: 8). Huyssen is not specifically referring to bunkers, but this aesthetic transformation of rubble into ruins provides a vocabulary for addressing recent conflict that has become central to the exploration of the bunker's cultural significance. One of the dangers here is that the recuperation of bunkers as ruins flirts with, as Brian Dillon suggests, "a kind of military-industrial sublime" that risks degenerating into nostalgia (2010). The dangerous pull of nostalgia, while integral to the bunker's ambivalent status as modern ruin, has to some extent been arrested by Svetlana Boym's distinction between "restorative" and "reflective" nostalgia. For Boym, restorative nostalgia is about "patching up the memory gaps" (2001: 41) and rebuilding the lost home so often mourned by nationalist movements invested in re-creating notionally lost traditions, values, and institutions. Reflective nostalgia, on the other hand, is about the "imperfect process of remembrance" (2001: 41); it is not about returning to the past but about understanding "the irrevocability of the past" through "shattered fragments of memory and temporalize[d] space" (2001: 49). Reflective nostalgia is, in short, ambivalent.

Drawing on Boym, Huyssen links the current fascination with industrial and military "ruins" with "urban preservation, remakes, and retrofashions, all of which seem to express a fear or denial of the ruination by time" (2006: 8). Hirst's objection to the bunker-as-ruin is

correct if the conventions of the picturesque still hold, but for Huyssen, the "chance for things to age and become ruin has diminished in the age of turbo capitalism." Instead of the time-softened relics of previous ages, the twenty-first century ruin is, Huyssen argues, "either detritus or restored age" (2006: 10). This assessment captures something of the peculiarities of the bunker's contemporary relevance. The awkwardness of the bunker's status within conventional categories of monument, architecture, and ruin, precisely because of the bunker's ambivalent place in the cultural imaginary, reveals how bunkers have come to embody intensely and necessarily conflicted attitudes toward power, security, and history.

DUMB BRUTES

If Virilio's bunker archaeology was a means of disrupting aesthetic categories by the insertion of found military architecture into the discourse of modernism, in the post-Cold War period, as Huyssen's comments suggest, an adjustment of terminology has enabled the bunker to enter the culture as ruinous object of fascination. In the visual arts and the heritage industry, bunkers and other military installations have become a preoccupation that serves as shorthand for an unflinching, serious-minded interrogation of the legacy of conflict.

In photography, following Virilio, the blankness of the concrete structure and its often incongruous (though increasingly expected) presence within an otherwise unmodified natural landscape has been effectively exploited by "straight" photographers in the United States, in the work, for example, of Richard Misrach (1990, 1996) and Peter Goin (1991) dealing with Western American test sites, and by European photographers such as Peter Seidel (1993), Hetum Gruber (1995), Bernard Dubuis (2001), Leo Fabrizio (2004), Boris Becker (2009), and Martin Roemers (2010). In the UK, John Kippin (2001) has produced an analogous body of work dealing with Greenham Common while Gilad Ophir (2001) and Roi Kuper adopt a similar position in images of abandoned Israeli military camps. There is almost never any sign of human life in these photographs and no trace of movement. Often it is hard if not impossible to locate the pictures in time or space, since the environments in which the bunkers are situated tend to be generic desert, plain, forest, field, or hillside. In the majority of cases the emphasis is on the exterior of the bunker, its obdurate stillness and its only partially successful attempt to appear organic or geological. The general unremarkability of many of the bunkers in these photographs contributes to a kind of minimalist dumbness that has come to characterize the bunker photograph as a sub-genre. In part, the pictures reproduce the affectlessness of the buildings, though whether this is a consequence of a dominant documentary mode of representation or a response to the subject matter is hard to say. The inference seems to be that the structures must be made to speak for themselves, that the camera is only incidentally present as recording device; or, like André Kertész's Paris shopfronts, Walker Evans's clapboard churches,

Lewis Baltz's tract houses, or Ed Ruscha's Sunset Strip, the main job of the object is to be there when the photographer turns up to add its likeness to his collection. Yet in their reticence, bunker photographs are in danger of reproducing the only apparent neutrality of the object, since the achieved violence of the bunker's presence in the landscape remains an affront.

Bunker photographs are compelling because of the bunkers rather than because of the photographs; the content dominates the form in the same way bunkers dominate the landscape. The photograph, like Macfarlane's Orford Ness, becomes implicated in the bunker's military aura and potentially complicit with it. This is not to say that the photographs are flawed because they are complicit, only that complicity is a function of the bunker's ambivalence and as such is integral to the bunker's uncomfortable cultural power. One way to expose and interrogate the distasteful charisma of the bunker-as-icon is to amplify it, and both Erasmus Schroeter (2002) and Uta Kögelsberger (2004) have floodlit wrecked bunkers, producing images that eschew naturalistic color and authenticity of setting by casting a garish light upon the scene (Figure 3). The results are consciously theatrical and otherworldly, the bunker's attempt to achieve camouflaged, naturalized invisibility refused by the strange illumination of nocturnal space.

Schroeter's and Kögelsberger's work insists that the bunkers participate in their own spectacle rather than be allowed to passively manage the affective environment merely by their presence. Similarly, Magdalena Jetelová's photographs of modified phrases from Virilio's *Bunker Archeology* projected upon Atlantic Wall bunkers subordinate the building to the effect (Figure 4). Here the bunker is both object and background, the material and the screen upon which its status

Figure 3
Uta Kögelsberger, Hartlepool, from Bunker Series, 2004. Courtesy of Uta Kögelsberger.

is interrogated (see Kimpel 2006). Gábor Ösz has also drawn directly on Virilio's work in *The Liquid Horizon* (Ösz 2000; 2003), a series of Atlantic Wall images that show not the bunkers themselves but the coast taken from inside them (Figure 5). Ösz turned the bunker into a camera obscura so, as he explains, "the bunker itself could be able to take a picture of the landscape" (Ösz 2003). Here, Ösz grasps what other bunker photographers only intimate: that camera and bunker are aspects of the same technology of surveillance and targeting. The blankness previously noted in many photographs of bunkers that repeats the blankness of the concrete is, in Ösz's photographs, put to work. Using Cibachrome paper and exposures of between six and eight hours, the resulting images, in a striking reversal of most bunker photography, do not concentrate on an inert moment but, as Ösz explains, the "circumstances around the bunkers, the capricious weather conditions and sometimes the lively presence of bathers." These elements "form a continuous element of the picture in the making" (2003). When the bunker cannot be seen but is instead the agent of seeing, its capacity to dominant and militarize the environment is arrested in favor of ongoing process and movement.

In different ways, Schroeter, Kögelsberger, Jetelová, and Ösz implicate the bunker in the process of representation and as such refuse to allow it to camouflage itself as a "natural" part of the environment. While this avoids the feigned neutrality of the documentary image, one danger is that the bunker becomes reanimated as aesthetic spectacle even as the work purports to critically examine the spectacularizing process. When Macfarlane complains that it is hard at a military site not to feel its "influence upon one's vision," there is an element of resistance there that is overridden in the next line as the hare "explodes" from a divot. But there is resistance, an unwelcomeness toward militarized influence and how it shapes the way things are made to look. In the work of Schroeter, Kögelsberger, and Jetelová, as well as in the

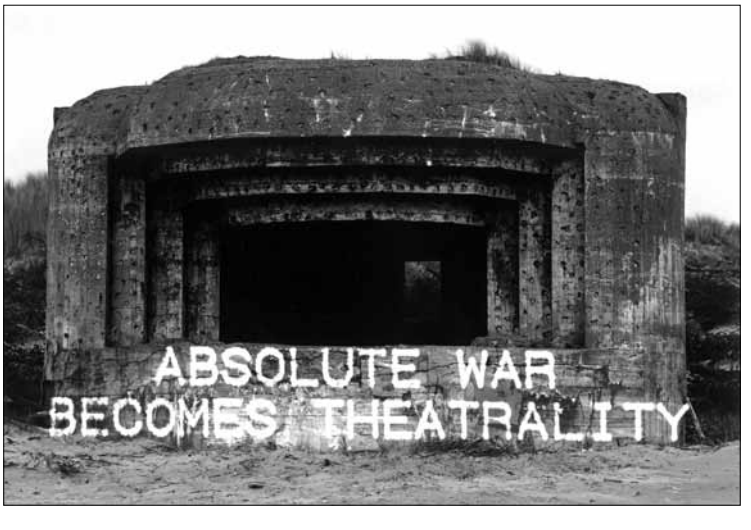

Figure 4
Magdalena Jetelová, Atlantic Wall, 1995. Silver gelatin print on aluminum. 124 × 180 cm. Photographs by Werner J. Hannappel. Courtesy of Magdalena Jetelová.

Figure 5
Gábor Ösz, No.4 Fécamp.13.09.1999. Exposure time: 6h 20m. Cibachrome, Camera Obscura. 126 × 228.4 cm. Courtesy of Gábor Ösz.

less interventionist bunker photographers, there is an antagonistic relationship between viewer and subject that is peculiar not least because the object of the photograph is an inanimate object. Yet the bunker, though without agency as such, is not without affective power, and the struggle to resist militarized vision is tested in each photograph. The alternative is not just complicity but affirmation.

The implication of the photographer and the viewer in the production of the bunker-as-spectacle is directly addressed in Jane and Louise Wilson's *Sealander* multi-screen installation (2006), where stills of Atlantic Wall bunkers are intercut with images of a huge-eyed vampire squid (Wilson 2007). Invoking the subterranean networks of optical surveillance and power that underpin the bunker's authority, the movement of the squid is a reminder that bunker images are never neutral surfaces but always underwritten by concealed and murky histories. One effect of "staging" the bunker is to challenge the reified military structure as a stable and achieved presence. Photographs of bunkers can only suggest the way the bunker physically occupies space but, as in Macfarlane's comments, it is clear that the bunker produces a militarized situation that naturalizes its own presence. To explicitly theatricalize the bunker through floodlighting or projection is to expose the edifice to the challenge made by Michael Fried in his well-known 1967 critique of minimalist sculpture; that is, that the quest for "objecthood" in sculpture in the end produces theatre because the artwork-as-object dominates and governs the space as spectacle. Fried objects to the way minimalists claim to be interested in the inscrutability of things but are in fact making anthropomorphic structures (Fried 1998: 157).[3] The same might be said of the ruined bunker: its condition as constructed and emplaced military structure is effaced by its seeming permanent condition as inert mass. By insisting on the bunker-as-spectacle through intensification of the lighting or by projecting upon its surface, artists like Schroeter, Kögelsberger, and Jetelová expose and resist the bunker's apparent singularity and call attention to the historical contingency of its place in the landscape.

Minimalism's disavowal of the referential function of art does not necessarily diminish the surface similarities between, for example, Donald Judd's concrete works at the Chinati Foundation in Marfa, Texas, and the serial pillboxes threaded along the East Anglian coastline. For European artists like Joachim Bandau and Peter Jacobi, the stubborn literalism of minimalist sculpture and the bunker's overdetermined blankness are close enough to generate work that interrogates the relationship between warfare and modernist aesthetics. Bandau's sculptures of the late 1970s are explicit in this regard, the minimalist obsession with geometric form and industrial materials moving between straight abstraction and direct reference to bunkers. Jacobi's interest in modularity similarly brings together the influence of Brancusi and the prefabricated concrete of Atlantic Wall fortifications, his 2002 Bucharest retrospective, in its title "Palimpsest," calling attention not only to a layering of the modernist sculptural tradition but also to the ways time and history are at once concealed and revealed by working over and scratching away the remains of the past. Jacobi's Holocaust memorial in Bucharest (2009) and other bunker-like memorials of recent years, such as Rachel Whiteread's Judenplatz Holocaust Memorial (2000) in Vienna and Peter Eisenman's Memorial to the Murdered Jews of Europe in Berlin (2005), appropriate the monumentality implicit in the military bunker but seek to cancel the violence of the bunker's presence by instead deploying the same kind of brute presence as a defiant refusal to forget (Figure 6). The Berlin memorial in particular strikingly recalls Bandau's drawing *Bunker-Siedlung* (bunker settlement) from 1978 in its use of minimalist geometry to imply at once claustrophobic containment and infinite serial repetition (Figure 7). The bunker's monolithic ubiquity in postwar Europe, not to mention its genetic relationship to the geometric modernist concrete slab, means that even in remembrance the bunker shadows efforts to grasp the legacies of World War Two.

Reading memorials as bunkers might also, as Jacobi's and Bandau's work indicates, open the possibility of thinking of bunkers as memorials in the ways suggested by Huyssen. The negotiation of the bunker's ambivalence through the plausibility of the military structure as a form of counter-monument is implicit in much of the work I have discussed here, the bunker functioning as a site of trauma which, as Cathy Caruth

Figure 6
Peter Eisenmann, Memorial to the Murdered Jews of Europe, Berlin, Germany, 2005. © iStockphoto.com/Ingenui.

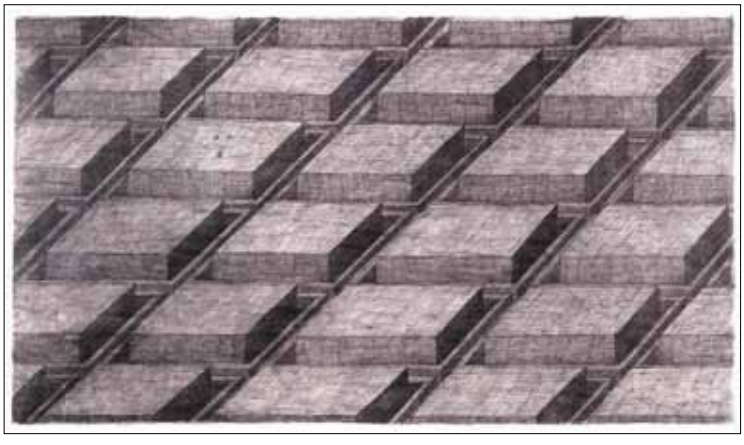

Figure 7
Joachim Bandau, Bunker-Siedlung. 2.1.1978. Pencil, tea, milk, and paper. 100 × 175 cm. Courtesy of Joachim Bandau.

explains, produces an "oscillation between a *crisis of death* and the correlative *crisis of life*: between the story of the unbearable nature of an event and the story of the unbearable nature of its survival" (1996: 7). Bauman's notion of ambivalence is predicated on the fact of modernity's generation of permanent crisis, and Caruth's conception of history as an oscillation between forms of unbearability is one form that this crisis might take. Minimalist sculpture, brutalist architecture, and the retrieval of World War Two military structures as a legitimate subject for historical and aesthetic interrogation are not, in these terms, unrelated. Minimalism's questions of seriality and objecthood are not formal issues that can for long remain aloof from the historical legacies of war and genocide. The reduction of the human subject to the status of object and the consequences of removing the distinction between human and non-human objects that World War Two normalized – in death camps, in the mobilization of entire populations, and in the targeting of cities, for example – place minimalism's ontological ambivalence at the heart of the postwar existential crisis. Nor can postwar solutions to the housing and management of mass urban populations be separated from the ruined cities and mass death they had to build upon. Implicit in the brutalist civic edifice and the minimalist primary structure is the infinite reproducibility of identical units, the imposition of mathematically derived grid structures upon an uneven and contingent life-world, and the naturalizing effect of this geometrical vision through the seeming permanence – concreteness – of its presence. These profoundly ambivalent aspects of modernity's compulsion to tidy up the chaos it has itself created are all functions of the military bunker which might properly be seen as the ur-structure that underpins, generates, and also challenges the permanent condition of war since World War Two.

In its recent return as memorial, the bunker suggests how the artistic and architectural working-through of the military site's implications has to some extent become more than a vanguardist preoccupation. This is certainly true with regard to the ways in which World War Two and Cold War military remains have become an intense focus of the heritage

industry. This is not to say that the disquiet registered by Virilio and others toward bunkers has dissipated, but Caruth's oscillation between a crisis of death and a crisis of life is in many ways – as Huyssen's comments on "urban preservation, remakes, and retrofashions" make clear – an increasingly institutionalized cultural tendency.

THE UNBEARABLE NATURE OF ITS SURVIVAL

Bunkers throughout the world have become ready-made tourist attractions since the end of the Cold War, and Mallory and Ottar's complaint in the early 1970s that there was a dearth of published material on military construction has been answered by an avalanche of illustrated guides, handbooks, and websites. The Defence of Britain Project, for example, funded by the Heritage Lottery Fund and the Imperial War Museum and run by the Council for British Archaeology between April 1995 and March 2002, employed 600 volunteers to record nearly 20,000 twentieth century anti-invasion defense sites across the UK. The Project's findings have produced two huge online databases and a growing library of publications.[4] Specialist publishers such as Osprey have also developed series dealing with twentieth century fortifications.[5] A recent trilingual handbook of Atlantic Wall installations is not an update of Virilio's meditation on total war but a guide for ramblers (Rolf 2008). The inventories of bunker designs, grid references, photographic documentation, and logistical and administrative background collected in these volumes provides a staggering level of detail, placing twentieth century military fortifications on a footing with steam railways and classic cars, with their own esoteric terminology – Lincolnshire three-bay, Dover Quad, Pickett-Hamilton Fort, Essex Lozenge – and rarity value.

The military bunker has become an established component of the "enrichment," "dark," or war tourist's itinerary (Frow 1991; Diller and Scofidio 1996; Lennon and Foley 2000; Berger 2006), with conventional tourist expectations such as beautiful surroundings also provided due to the fact that so many military installations were deliberately built in remote or secluded areas. The Hack Green Secret Nuclear Bunker in Nantwich, for example, promises views of "the picturesque farmland and rolling Cheshire countryside" but reminds visitors that "it was not always like this!" The incongruity of exposed "secret" military installations is patently a large part of their attraction, and the jarring collision of rolling countryside and high-tech bunkers produces an uncanny effect of insecure security, a suspension of everyday domestic life that at the same time attempts to domesticate that which threatens it. It is this irreducible awkwardness of military remains that is captured by the English Heritage website's description of the York Cold War Bunker as the organization's "most modern and spine-chilling" property. Visitors are advised not to miss the decontamination room or "a trip to the shop to stock up on English Heritage goodies."

The preservation and education agendas are, unsurprisingly, heavily foregrounded in the promotional materials of sites funded

with government money. While this is clearly intended to neutralize the more troubling aspects of the existence of the sites and their intended functions, the "spine-chilling" dimension is inevitably also part of the equation, and an attraction that eviscerates completely the claustrophobic and frightening attributes of a military site is unlikely to succeed in its educational or recreational mission. Part of the mechanism of reassurance provided for the visitor, as well as the contextual gesture toward familiar and relaxing landscape and the reminders of how things are no longer dangerous, is the self-reflexive strategy of narrating the process through which the site has been rescued from abandonment. This not only serves to show how money has been spent but also recuperates the site as part of the ongoing process of making secure previously amorphous threats. The Liverpool War Museum website, for example, includes photographs of the Western Approaches bunker in its "derelict state" and in its current, reconstructed condition. An integral part of the narrative of the site's history, then, is redemptive: the disturbingly invisible has been made safe for view.

The problem with this process of retrieval is that it serves to gut the site of the awful connotations that make it historically relevant in the first place. The irony is not lost even on the archaeologist John Schofield, whose job it is to identify military sites for English Heritage preservation and who has published widely on the practical and theoretical aspects of defense heritage. Schofield concedes that it is "the places without funding or conservation [that] are often also the most evocative" (2005: 171). While Schofield is understandably invested in presenting the case for saving bunkers and other sites, and draws on a range of strategies, including the relevance of artistic interventions, to demonstrate how such places are culturally important, the implicit violence at the heart of any military installation, however smartly it is renovated, remains unresolved.[6] It is violence that is evoked at the non-conserved sites in all its complex and affective forms; it may also be violence that is evoked at retrofitted tourist bunkers, but now it is violence mediated by the apparatus of recreation and heritage. As Don DeLillo writes in *Underworld* (1997), tourists "travel somewhere not for museums and sunsets but for ruins, bombed-out terrain, for the moss-grown memory of torture and war" (248). In other words, the modern tourist wants an aestheticized violence generated by the awkward combination of the authentic and the picturesque.

It is worth remembering that the National Trust decided not to demolish the pagodas at Orford Ness in the early 1990s; this awareness of what one of the British defense preservation studies calls the "fearsome heritage" (Cocroft and Schofield 2007) of conflict gives many otherwise unremarkable sites powerful ambient clout. Increasingly, artists and other cultural workers are less likely to deal with military buildings as found material and will more probably be funded for residencies and installations by the owner of a decommissioned site. In this way, while serious and powerful work may still result, as in Louise K. Wilson's

projects at Orford Ness and Spadeadam (Wilson 2006), the extent to which this kind of institutionalized "intervention" into militarized space normalizes the bunker-as-artwork is not unproblematic.

The folding of art into the heritage bunker might be seen as part of a broader mainstreaming of the artistic avant-garde's longstanding fixation with the military, which is in the process of converting art's adversarial position into a cultural norm. Polish artist Robert Kusmirowski's 2009 installation at The Barbican's Curve gallery in London, entitled simply *Bunker,* converted the gallery itself into a bunker by constructing a series of rooms and corridors full of broken-down equipment and machinery. The simultaneous proximity and distance of Kusmirowski's bunker space to its enfolding environment produces an effect that is authentic and phony at the same time. With so many bunkers renovated as tourist attractions, part of the strangeness of *Bunker* is the way it apes real bunkers that now perform as simulations of themselves. What distances *Bunker* from the tourist bunkers, though, is the dust and the absence of instructional labels. While the tourist bunker has somehow to create a narrative of redemption out of the remains of a previous site of threat and conflict, Kusmirowski's bunker, created within a development built out of the craters of the Blitz, instead concentrates on generating an affectively threatening authentic space out of a collection of unrelated bits of junk.

Kusmirowski's installation is a reminder of the gallery's function as a passive aggressive storehouse of cultural treasures, a connection embraced with less apparent disquiet in the trend for transforming actual bunkers into art galleries. The massive multistory bunker on Reinhardstrasse in Berlin designed by Albert Speer, for example, is now home to the advertising entrepreneur Christian Boros's collection of contemporary art (Boros Foundation 2009), joining similar enterprises in München and Nuremburg. Outside Germany, Mussolini's bunker under the Palazzo degli Uffici in Rome is now also an art gallery, while recent military excavation in Moscow of a tunnel supposedly leading to Stalin's bunker is also to become a gallery. Further afield, the former military island of Kinmen, located between mainland China and Taiwan, had its 2,000 bunkers transformed in 2004 by Cai Guo-Chang into the Bunker Museum of Contemporary Art (Vine 2005; Cai 2006). Even when the structure itself is not a decommissioned bunker, the connection is too hard to resist, as in the case of Krakow's 1965 exhibition hall which, after years of being contemptuously referred to as "the bunker," was in the mid 1990s officially renamed as Bunker of Arts.

The robustness of the bunker-as-gallery provides not only a suitably secure vault for art's luxury goods but gives a dubious ambient gravitas to even the most anodyne collection. The passive aggression of a building like the Boros bunker also provides a ready-made defiance of the kind Marcel Breuer sought to manufacture by wedging his modernist Whitney Museum building (1966) into the precincts of New York City's Madison Avenue. Whatever is inside the art bunker, the building itself trades on the confrontational stance once associated

with non-affirmative artforms but which is now folded back into the gestures of an achieved cultural domination.

Just as brutalist architecture can now be read both as the empty display of a power that was squirreled away elsewhere and an excrescence of the anxiety produced by power's invisibility, the retrofitting of World War Two bunkers and the unveiling of Cold War installations also demonstrates the success of the military in being able to conceal itself from public view. In this way the authority of the new tourist site lies in its capacity to demonstrate the way in which military secrets can be withdrawn and revealed at will. The tourist bunker is a spectacle of covert operations; showing the facility exposes our previous ignorance of its existence, and the belated invitation to view is predicated on its current uselessness. One of the implications here is that it is only safe for the public to know about things that are effectively redundant. The liberty to restore a bunker as museum or gallery and the ingenuity with which concealed or feared sites of terror have been recuperated as spaces of cultural speculation is a freedom to enter and look upon what is constructed as a lost world. In some ways, to paraphrase Caruth, the preservation of the bunker has made all too bearable the nature of its survival.

On the other hand, just as Virilio's Atlantic Wall project provides a way of looking askance at Cold War secrecy and war memorials appropriate the architecture of aggression as a modality of mourning, it may be that even in its commodified forms the bunker retains its power to speak, with all its dumb force, of an undiminished oscillation between the crisis of life and the crisis of death. As the relics of twentieth century conflict are preserved, memorialized, and retooled, Virilio's point that "the new fortress" is underfoot and invisible is confirmed in the deployment of sewers, tunnels, and other subterranean bunkered spaces of what Simon Guy calls the "shadow architecture" (Graham 2004: 75) of twenty-first century conflict. Current security anxieties about the prevalence of concealed underground weapons facilities replay the fears of the Cold War while the utilization of caves and complex tunnel systems by terrorists and border-crossing migrants also continues to defy high-tech surveillance systems. The failure to extract Osama bin Laden from the cave complex he was believed to have constructed at Tora Bora, despite the use of the optimistically named "bunker-buster" bombs, suggests the continuing capacity of the bunker to frustrate assault and its persistence as ambivalent site of cultural and military anxiety (on bunker busters, see Phelan 2004). In the case of bin Laden, the bunker complex was no more than a conjuration of the US military, indicative of a mindset struggling to conceive of an enemy not locatable in a fortified den.

Defunct bunkers, however imbricated in economic and cultural systems of affirmation, still work as surrogates for the real but unknowable systems of security and governance that continue to shape the limits of what can be exposed and documented. As restrictions on photography become more widespread and public space becomes

increasingly monitored and managed by private interests deploying a discourse of security to discipline and regulate populations, the attention paid to the bunkers of previous conflicts begins to emerge as a mode of oblique critical interrogation and an expression of persistent and deep ambivalence. That which can be seen, occupied, and modified stands as a necessary substitute for that which remains aloof, spectral, and threatening. While it could be argued that this substitution is precisely what is achieved by the renovation of sites of aggression by the heritage business, the stubborn fact of the bunker as, to recall Sebald, a "monolithic, monstrous incarnation of ugliness and blind violence" refuses, in the end, to yield to the seductions of the military-industrial-leisure complex. It is this very blankness, its double valence as refuge and tomb, that has made the bunker an embodiment of so many of the twentieth century's horrors. The disturbing and relentless oscillation between life and death, ruin and rubble, nature and culture, exposure and concealment, image and object, art and atrocity, that vibrates deep in the rebars of the bunker's reinforced concrete is the tremor of modernity's ambivalence no amount of cultural recuperation can, or should, contain.

Nevertheless, as part of the infrastructure of the leisure industry, the kind of shock often registered by writers and artists in apprehending bunkers in the landscape has to a considerable extent been absorbed by the pacifying narratives that support their preservation. The respect which World War Two and Cold War sites now enjoy as places of archaeological, historical, and memorial interest has no doubt been hard won, but the problem with legitimacy is that it can close down antagonistic interpretations and burn off the impurities that make such places relevant. As Kusmirowski's installation seems to suggest, thinking about military installations must now also involve a critical interrogation of their overdetermined status in the culture. Without a reflexive awareness of the bunker's relevance to contemporary discourses of secrecy and security the danger is that the restored or protected remains of military sites will function merely to distance and cordon off the frightening implications of their existence as past times. What Virilio and others identified in the bunker is its capacity to generate what Foucault calls a history of the present and to gesture towards invisible continuations of its legacy. Part of that legacy, it now seems, is the spectacle of power the bunker performs in its afterlife as icon of and venue for displaced fantasies of military aggression. Heritage itself – as an idea and an industry – has become not only a primary mediator of the bunker's historical significance but an intrinsic part of the bunker's intolerable history. As such, the management of military sites as heritage oscillates dangerously between offering a critical interrogation of those sites and reiterating military power's capacity for display as a mode of concealment. It is now, perhaps, not only the unbearable story of the event that requires attention but what is most pressing is a radical rethinking of the unbearable story of its survival.

NOTES

1. For a more sustained argument about the visible and invisible in relation to militarized space, see Beck (2009), especially chapter 1, and Paglen (2009).
2. Colomina (2006) provides a wide-ranging examination of the ways the militarized culture of the Cold War permeated postwar domestic architecture and design.
3. For a discussion of the importance of the brutalist building as "image," see Banham (1996) and Stalder (2008).
4. See, for example, Lowry (1998); Foot (2006a, 2006b); and Osborne (2004, 2008). The Royal Commission on the Historical Monuments of England conducted a similar project in 1999 that dealt with Cold War buildings. See Cocroft and Thomas (2003).
5. See, for example, Allcorn (2003); McGovern and Smith (2006); and Zaloga (2007, 2008, 2009).
6. For extensive discussion of these issues, see Schofield (2004; 2005; 2009); Schofield and Cocroft (2007); and Schofield, Johnson, and Beck (2002).

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